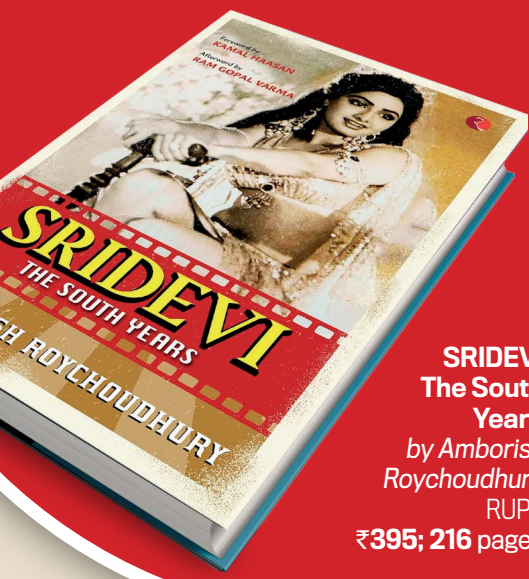


SRIDEVI
The South Years
by Amborish Roychoudhury
RUPA
₹395; 216 pages

tory of expressions and gestures is invoked with admiration by several directors.

Unabashedly a Sridevi fan who finds greatness in her earlier acting, Roychoudhury is also a critic who sees her turn in *Moondram Pirai* (the Hindi *Sadma*) as the "performance of a lifetime", but comments on the "bizarre cocktail of expressions" she invoked to portray childishness. Where do we find ourselves on this scale? Read the book, let it be your guide to her roles, and enjoy making up your own mind. ■

Juhi Saklani

Kashmir are inextricably intertwined. *'The room of the houseboat was just the same except there was no bukhari here—the room used to have the soft warmth of belongingness due to the bukhari. My soul and I were lying cold here.'* We wonder how the original in Hindi, published in June 2022, reads. But the English version, translated by Pooja Priyamvada, seems to speak in Kaul's authentic voice. Every other line makes you stop and ponder. *'Now here in Kashmir I can comprehend his silence. By spending just some time in Kashmir I have begun to understand how and when we become quiet. The silence resembled my father.'* Kaul also uses *Rooh* to gently probe the wounds of the people of the Valley, presenting many sides of the equation via conversations, fleeting as well as in-depth, some perplexing, others profound. He offers slices of reality seasoned with the mystique of surrealism. Even as he claims not to belong, is often afraid of being lost, his words reflect a distinct Sufi soul, which is the essence of Kashmiriyat. ■

Priya Pathiyan

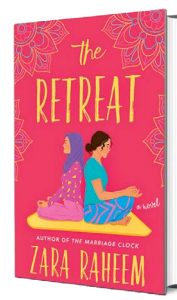
BOOKS

OF MARRIAGE AND MORALS

Zara Raheem's *The Retreat* is about South Asian lives as they play out in American suburbia

The central premise of this book is familiar: South Asian people trying to live their South Asian lives in the middle of uncaring white culture. I could almost see the words 'in the style of Monica Ali' floating above the text, but alas, without the wit, charm and brilliance of Ali's writing.

This shortfall is not just because Raheem's setting is the manufactured peace of American suburbia rather than the churn of big, noisy London. The feeling I got from the book was that the writer is struggling to connect with her readers, but her training is holding her back. The book has the overbrushed technical smoothness that characterises the output of American writing programmes, and this product placement is at war with the rawness that lies deep underneath.



THE RETREAT
By Zara Raheem
WILLIAM MORROW
₹499; 352 pages

Raheem tries to show her central character, Nadia, as a person torn between her desire to be a model wife and mother, and her real-life failure to be either, but none of Nadia's problems seem solid enough to care about. The trouble in Nadia's marriage turns out to be the result of a failure of communication, and the denouement is not the kind of gender spectrum representation I would expect to see. In fact, it veers on genderqueer stereotyping, and it's dropped in too late in the book to be anything other than a plot device.

In between, there are digs at white culture's embracing of yoga and Eastern philosophy, but the ideal yoga-babe whom Nadia suspects of stealing her husband turns out to be nothing but a Ganga who has gotten a little *maili*. It turns out that Nadia cannot compete with the person who's really stolen her hubby's heart. In the hands of a writer like Ali or Meera Syal, this situation could have produced both delicious humour and profound pathos, but here it's just a convenient way to extract Nadia from her dilemma and move her on. Has she learned anything or been changed in any way? We are told she has, but I am not convinced.

The story ends with just a hint that conventional true love is on its way to Nadia, thereby providing the reader with a feelgood send-off. You can enjoy this book if you come to it with low expectations, but you aren't likely to remember much after you're done. ■

Rimi B. Chatterjee